THE VALLEY OF DEATH

A HILLSIDE DOTTED WITH FIRE

In the higher reaches of the Himalayas, October is the golden period. The silt-carrying muddy waters in most of the glacier-fed streams have usually settled down by the second week of September and all the water in the trans-Himalayan arid zone turns aquamarine blue, while in the forest covered slopes on the southern side of the watershed the crystal clear waters appear to be a dark shade of green. Almost all villages, depending on their altitude and location, are either still harvesting or have finished harvesting their crops. Everyone is busy stocking up for the coming winter months, when temperatures plummet to way below zero.

On the night of 19 October 1962, temperatures in the Nam Ka Chu Valley had already dropped to below freezing levels even at the river's lowest point, which was the junction with the Nyamjang Chu just below the Khenzemane grazing ground. With the sun setting early because of the narrowness of the valley, there was no getting away from the cold. As darkness fell, Major Gurdial Singh, the 2IC of 2 Rajput, stood outside his bunker and watched in amazement as the northern slopes of the Nam Ka Chu Valley seemed to come alive with dozens of blazing campfires. Behind and slightly above Major Gurdial Singh's position was the Battalion HQ where the commanding officer, Lieutenant Colonel Maha Singh Rikh, along with three officers—his adjutant Captain Gurucharan Bhatia, Captain Mahavir Mangat and Lieutenant Bhup Singh—was also staring at the amazing display of nonchalance by the Chinese across the river.

The entire valley was lightly forested with bamboo, blue pine, rhododendron and other deciduous vegetation. On the northern side of the valley was the Thagla Ridge that dominated the entire Nam Ka Chu Valley. Due to the forest cover, visibility within the valley was limited to a maximum of 90 metres, though usually it was even less than that. However, further up on the slopes of the Thagla, the treeline thinned out appreciably.